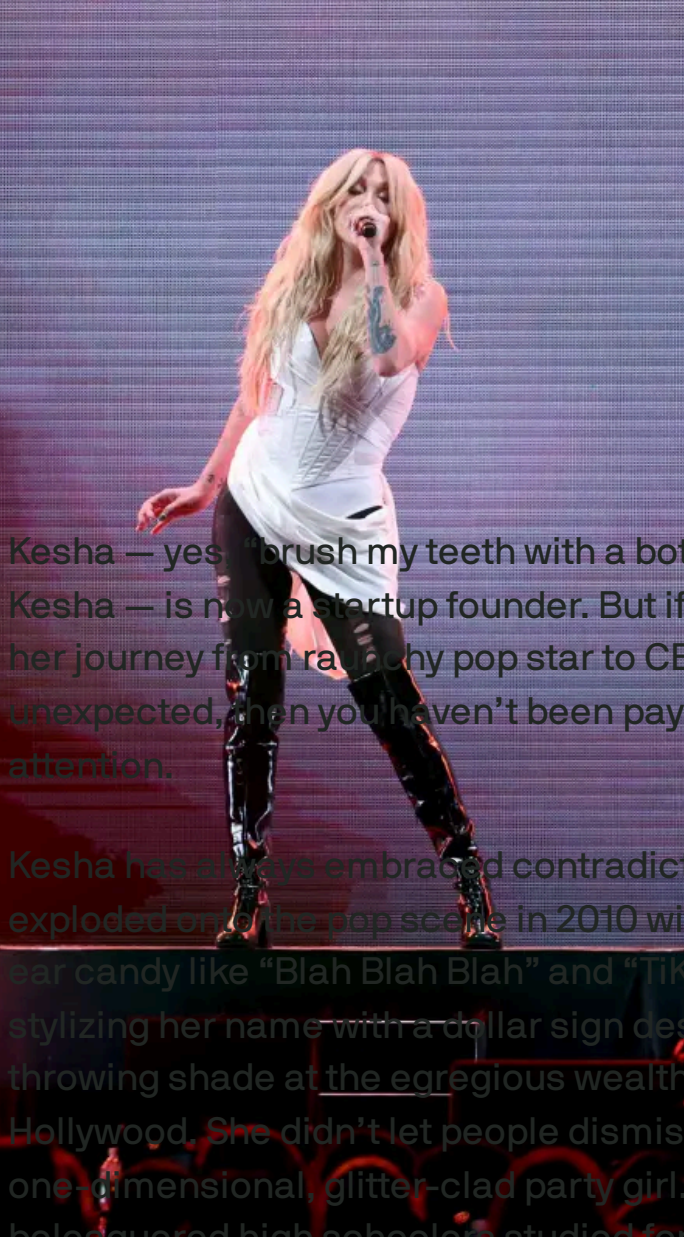


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With her app Smash,
Kesha can be whoever
she wants — even a tech
CEO

A photograph of Kesha performing on stage. She has long blonde hair and is wearing a white corset-style top and black pants. She is holding a microphone to her mouth and has her hand near her face. The background is a dark stage with some lighting effects.

Kesha — yes, “brush my teeth with a bottle of Jack” Kesha — is now a startup founder. But if you think her journey from raunchy pop star to CEO is unexpected, then you haven’t been paying attention.

Kesha has always embraced contradictions. She exploded onto the pop scene in 2010 with irreverent ear candy like “Blah Blah Blah” and “TiK ToK,” stylizing her name with a dollar sign despite throwing shade at the egregious wealth of Hollywood. She didn’t let people dismiss her as a one-dimensional, glitter-clad party girl. As beleaguered high schoolers studied for exams amid Kesha’s rise to fame, they whispered in frustration about how the world’s most famous party girl got [a near-perfect score on the SAT](#) but turned down a full ride to Barnard College to sing about peeing in champagne bottles.

IMAGE CREDITS: SCOTT EISEN / GETTY IMAGES

The biggest contradiction of Kesha’s story is that despite living the dream of a pop star on the surface, her years in the spotlight were nightmarish behind the scenes. Now, drawing from her own experience suffering at the hands of predatory record contracts, Kesha is building an app called [Smash](#), which is a way for musicians to find one another, make music together, and establish clear, artist-friendly contracts among collaborators.

Smash aims to set itself apart by using a built-in system to generate contracts between artists. The

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terms of the contracts depend on what each artist decides — for example, a musician may decide to license a beat for a set fee or request a percentage of royalties over time. Smash would fund itself by taking a small cut of payments made through the app.

“One of the pieces of leverage, especially over younger music creators, is you need a way into the club,” Kesha’s brother and Smash co-founder Lagan Sebert told TechCrunch. “With Smash, we want to give music creators the keys to get into this club of professionals and other creators without them feeling like they have to sign anything away, or make any large decisions about the rest of their lives.”

After establishing herself as a powerhouse pop star, Kesha sued her producer Dr. Luke in 2014 for alleged sexual, physical, and emotional abuse. He immediately countersued her for defamation, sparking a high-profile legal battle and reckoning with the dark side of pop music.

Though Kesha sought to get out of her recording contract with Dr. Luke, the court ruled against her, forcing her to release three more albums with him.

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It was only this month — on July 4, a date chosen very intentionally — that Kesha released an album without Dr. Luke for the first time. But regaining her own artistic agency isn't enough. Now that she is a fully independent artist, she wants to help ensure that other young musicians don't fall victim to exploitative record deals like she did.

“One of the things that really motivated her was when she went through this long legal battle to regain the rights to her voice, regain rights to her music,” Sebert said. “I think the motivation behind Smash more than anything was to try to give music creators access to the community they need to create music independently.”

Building the band

If Kesha and her brother were going to build an app, they were going to need some technological expertise.

Years ago, Kesha attended an ACTAI Ventures event and met Lars Rasmussen, who co-founded Google Maps and was one of the first investors in design unicorn Canva. The two stayed in touch, and when it came time to build Smash, Rasmussen introduced her to Alan Cannistraro, who would become the app's CTO.

Cannistraro spent over 12 years at Apple, where he worked on products for creatives like Final Cut; he also managed a team of engineers to build the first ever apps for iOS, like Remote, iBooks, iTunes, and Podcasts. He went on to start [Rheo](#), a social video startup, but he has always had an interest in music.

“In the late ‘90s, when my friends were all using Napster, I was saying to them, ‘What the hell, you like this music. Why are you screwing the artist?’” Cannistraro told TechCrunch. “It’s always just been in my value system that artists need to be supported.”

When Kesha, her brother Lagan, and Cannistraro started working together, Rasmussen became one of their first investors. Kesha even announced the app as part of Rasmussen’s Panathēnea festival in Greece.



“Smash is a community platform for music creators. It’s a place where you can go to connect, to create, and to hire, all while retaining the rights to what you create,” Kesha said at the festival. “The goal is to shift the power back to the hands of the creators.”

“The contracting is safe — it’s all transparent, and then you get to choose, and you get consent over where your art and where your voice goes, and how it goes into the world, all while retaining the rights to what you have just created,” she added.

The Smash app remains a work in progress, intending to open to some artists later this year. But to test some of the tech tools that the company has created thus far, Smash hosted a contest where artists could submit [remixes](#) of Kesha’s song “Boy Crazy” — the five winners of the contest will have

their remixes released on Kesha’s record label for what Sebert calls an “industry standard remix fee.”

“I regained the rights to my voice back for the first time in my adult life about one year ago, as a 37-year-old woman,” Kesha said at Panathēnea. “Predatory deals like that are normal.”

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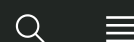


Amanda Silberling

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Kesha is now a startup founder



Amanda Silberling — 12:09 PM PDT · May 23, 2025

Kesha may have [taken the dollar sign out](#) of her name, but now, the singer is thinking about money again — not for herself, but to fund the seed round of her new startup, [Smash](#).

According to [Kesha's Instagram post](#), Smash will be a "community-based platform to connect and protect music creators," which aligns with the mission of her new [eponymous record label](#), which she announced last year.

The 38-year-old chart-topper has always been more than a glitter-clad party girl singing about [brushing her teeth with Jack Daniel's](#). Beneath her infectious 2010s pop music is a darker story — one in which she felt [stripped of her power](#), both as an artist and a person, by a [predatory record deal](#) that she signed when she was a teenager.

After a [traumatic public legal battle](#) with her producer, Kesha now says that she is a ["free woman,"](#) and she's making new music. Both her label, Kesha Records, and the app Smash seek to help others make music without compromising their creative rights.

"I want a place where artists and music makers of any kind can have community, they can collaborate, they can hire each other and retain all the rights to everything they create," [Kesha said](#) in

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an interview with WIRED. “There’s no gatekeeping of contacts.”

She went on to describe the app as “LinkedIn for music creators,” or a “Fiverr-style marketplace.” The difference is that Smash plans to prioritize artists’ rights at every stage.

Kesha’s CTO on the project is Alan Cannistraro. He spent 12 years at Apple building some of the first iOS apps, then worked at Facebook, where he built the Year-In-Review feature. He left to start a social video platform called [Rheo](#), which TechCrunch covered in 2016.

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Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She...

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Apple Music subscribers can now get their own ‘year in review,’ too, thanks to this app

Sarah Perez — 10:56 AM PST · December 26, 2018

A new app offers Apple Music subscribers a way to look back at their favorite music of the year and

other streaming highlights, similar to Spotify's annual "Wrapped" feature. The app, from developer NoiseHub, is simply called "[Music Year in Review](#)," and its sole purpose is to offer Apple Music customers their own set of music streaming insights for 2018.

If you're not familiar with "Wrapped," it's [Spotify's data-rich yearly review](#) that allows you to find out things like your most-played artists and songs, top genres, minutes streamed, new music discoveries and more from the past year. The streaming service delivers these insights through a flashy, personalized website. It also puts your top 100 songs from the year into a playlist you can save to your own library.

[NoiseHub's new app](#), by comparison, is far more basic.

It only crunches the numbers across a few metrics: how many minutes you spent listening to your favorite artist this year on Apple Music, as well as your top five songs and artists, including which are your No. 1 favorites. It also will return your top genre of the year.

However, for Apple Music subscribers, there hasn't been an easy way to access this data before now. Unfortunately, Apple doesn't offer a personalized, annual review feature like Spotify's.

One caveat to using the new app is that NoiseHub asks for your email address to get started, which it says it uses to "save your data."

There isn't a further explanation as to whether or not that email will be used again in the future, nor is there a privacy policy link. If sharing your email makes you uncomfortable, you may want to just use a disposable address — it doesn't impact the

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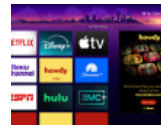
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app's ability to retrieve your data. (You can also skip email entry by tapping the arrow button.)



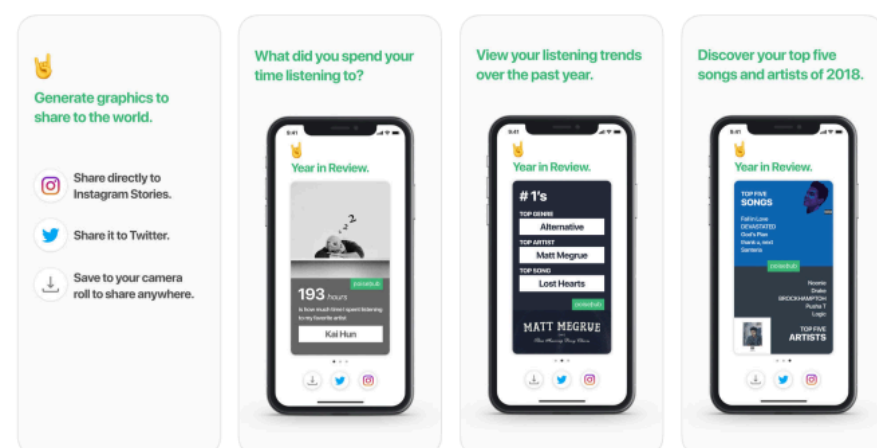
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Instead, NoiseHub pops up a permissions dialog box to request access to Apple Music in order to do its work.



It then returns a set of three graphics, the first featuring the time you spent with your top artist, the second with your No. 1s for the year (genre, artist and song) and the third with your top five songs and top five artists.

The graphics are designed to be posted to Instagram or Twitter with a tap on the included sharing buttons, or can be downloaded to your Camera Roll for sharing elsewhere.

The app was developed by [NoiseHub](#), a startup co-founded by [Samir Shekhawat](#) and [Alex Santarelli](#), which was previously [developing](#) a social network for music lovers.

“For the past few years, we’ve been working on a social music app called NoiseHub. During that time, as we made mistakes, we iterated slowly,” explains Music Year in Review app’s creator, Samir Shekhawat. “This application is still internal – it’s been a side project for years – but when we heard about Spotify’s 2018 Wrapped, we decided to take a brief break on NoiseHub and dedicate a weekend during finals week to create an Apple Music Year in Review,” he says.

The app may become a part of NoiseHub’s experience in the future, if the team decides to work on that project again. (They’ve stopped indefinitely for now.) In the meantime, they want to flesh out the annual review app with more data and add more graphics.

The [Music Year in Review app](#) is a free download on the App Store.

It still seems to be a bit of an undiscovered gem — there aren’t any public posts to speak of, and its [Dribbble](#) page has just 155 views.

While some early testers experienced a bug that led to crashes, the app worked for us without error. The reports stem from those who don’t have much data in Apple Music, in many cases. The team believes they have a bug fix, but the App Store is closed for the holidays.



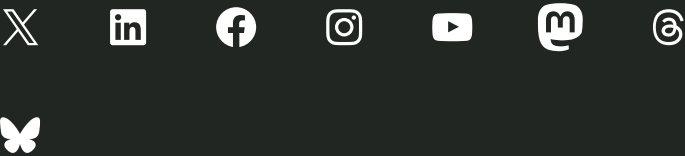
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